Rebecca: Themes

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Themes

Exam responses that are led by ideas are more likely to reach the highest levels of the mark scheme. Exploring the ideas of the text, specifically in relation to the question being asked, will help to increase your fluency and assurance in writing about the text.

Below are some ideas that could be explored in Rebecca. This list is not exhaustive and you are encouraged to identify other ideas within the text.

- **Identity**
- **Power and control**
- **Deception and secrets**
- **Class**

Identity

Through this theme, du Maurier explores self-perception, societal expectations and the influence of the past on one's sense of identity. Societal expectations, particularly those within the aristocratic ideals depicted in the novel, mean that characters are subjected to rigid norms that present a challenge to their identity and autonomy.

Knowledge and evidence:

- The deliberate choice to keep the novel's narrator nameless serves as a narrative device that is used to illustrate the theme of identity
- Early in the novel, the narrator expresses a longing to assume a different identity:
  - This foreshadows the identity (Rebecca) that she will replace
- The narrator's lack of a distinct identity reflects her ongoing struggle to define herself:
  - The narrator's jealousy of Rebecca permeates most of the novel
- By withholding the narrator's name, du Maurier creates a symbolic void:
  - It conveys the protagonist's struggle to establish a distinct identity within the oppressive confines of

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

anonymity accentuates her marginalised position:
    - It conveys the challenges she faces in asserting her identity

- This intentional anonymity could also be used to illustrate the universal nature of the struggles she undergoes in defining herself:
    - The narrator's hesitation to fully embrace her new title of Mrs de Winter stems from her sense of inadequacy in comparison to Rebecca

- Rebecca, although absent, is **omnipresent** through physical possessions:
    - This is evidenced in the meticulously preserved rooms and the collective memory of Manderley's staff

- The narrator is continually measured and judged against Rebecca's idealised image:
    - This fosters her sense of inadequacy and her perceived inability to live up to the standards set by her predecessor

- The theme of identity is evident in the direct comparison between the two women:
    - Rebecca is portrayed as confident and sophisticated, and effortlessly navigates the societal expectations imposed upon her
    - In contrast, the new Mrs de Winter is characterised by insecurity and self-doubt, and she struggles to assimilate into her role as the lady of Manderley:
        - This juxtaposition highlights the societal norms that dictate the perception of the ideal woman
        - It creates an unattainable standard that the protagonist feels compelled to meet

- Mrs Danvers contributes to the protagonist's sense of insecurity by magnifying the differences between the two women:
    - She becomes an unintentional catalyst for the protagonist and forces the narrator to confront her own identity and the idealised image of Rebecca

- The narrator's internal thoughts frequently revolve around the perceived virtues of Rebecca:
    - This reveals the extent to which her sense of self is entangled with the ghostly presence of Rebecca

- The revelation of Rebecca's secrets and her true nature contribute to the transformation of the narrator's self-perception:
    - The disparity between the public and private image of Rebecca makes the narrator reevaluate her own identity

- Further, the hierarchical nature of aristocratic society further complicates the protagonist's quest for identity:
    - The rigid class distinctions and the scrutiny of her peers intensify the pressure to conform

What is du Maurier's intention?

- Du Maurier raises questions about the tension between conforming to societal norms and asserting one's

Help me understand

identity
- The novel suggests that the journey towards self-discovery is often entangled with societal expectations and the influence of the past

Power and control

Rebecca explores how characters maintain power over others through manipulation, intimidation and other psychological tools. The narrator's weakness exposes her to those who are more powerful than her and characters like Mrs Danvers use her weakness to frighten, intimidate and manipulate her.

Knowledge and evidence:

- Mrs Danvers's loyalty to Rebecca becomes a source of control within Manderley:
  - Her deep devotion to her deceased mistress is evident in the preserved items and carefully maintained rooms associated with Rebecca
  - This loyalty is not merely a demonstration of affection, but a strategy through which Mrs Danvers exerts control over Manderley
- Mrs Danvers uses psychological tactics to maintain her influence over the new Mrs de Winter:
  - Her manipulation is subtle but sinister and she cleverly undermines the narrator's confidence
  - Her constant comparisons to Rebecca and the suggestion that the current Mrs de Winter can never measure up demonstrate her controlling influence
- Mrs Danvers's influence extends to the dynamics between Maxim and the new Mrs de Winter:
  - By actively perpetuating the memory of Rebecca as an idealised figure, she indirectly contributes to the power dynamics within the marriage
  - Thus, Rebecca's memory becomes a source of tension and control between Maxim and his second wife
- Mrs Danvers is a symbol of resistance to change:
  - She exploits the protagonist's vulnerabilities and ensures that her own position of authority within Manderley remains unchallenged
  - Her resistance to accepting the new Mrs de Winter illustrates her controlling behaviour
- Social norms and expectations also become a source of control:
  - Characters are expected to adhere to a predefined set of rules and this reinforces the hierarchical structure of society
  - This control extends to the realm of public perception and reputation as deviation from established norms, or any behaviour deemed inappropriate, would be frowned upon:
    - It influences characters to conform to societal expectations to preserve their standing within this

interactions between the characters
    - The household staff, as well as the narrator, respond and adapt to his moods

- Furthermore, the significant age gap between Maxim and his wife and the circumstances surrounding their union contribute to a power imbalance

What is du Maurier's intention?

- The novel explores how love can coexist with, or be challenged by, the inherent power structures within a relationship
- The novel invites readers to consider the consequences of authority, the manipulation that can arise from power and the ways in which individuals address and resist these power structures

Deception and secrets

The tension between appearance and reality contributes to the mysterious tone of the novel. The text explores the consequences of hidden truths and the impact of deception and secrets on characters and their relationships.

Knowledge and evidence:

- Truth remains elusive throughout much of the narrative and many characters are linked to deception and secrets
    - From the outset, the unreliable first-person narrator establishes an atmosphere of deceit
    - The narrator frequently masks her true thoughts and emotions to other characters:
        - Her own self-deception is evident in her attempt to live up to the idealised image of Rebecca and suppress her own insecurities

- The narrator also conceals her uncertainties and fears regarding her relationship with Maxim:
    - The pressure to conform to the role of the ideal wife creates a constant tension between her true self and her projected persona

- Maxim's concealment of the circumstances surrounding Rebecca's death contributes to the novel's atmosphere of secrecy:
    - His reluctance to reveal the truth reflects his inner guilt
    - The deception surrounding Maxim's past deeply impacts his relationship with the new Mrs de Winter

- As a character, Mrs Danvers is central to the novel's theme of deception:
    - Her deceitful actions aid in driving the narrator to the point of despair, to the extent that the narrator contemplates suicide
    - She uses her knowledge and position to perpetuate a distorted and false version of Rebecca and the past in order to control and manipulate the narrator

her infidelity alters the reader's perception of her

- She deliberately deceives Maxim into making him think she is pregnant

What is du Maurier's intention?

- Du Maurier suggests that deception can have destructive consequences:
- The characters' attempts to maintain façades and hide uncomfortable truths have a corrosive impact on their lives
- The novel conveys the burden of guilt and the pressures to conform to societal expectations

Class

Rebecca explores the power imbalances associated with class distinctions. The narrator's lower class and interactions between the aristocratic de Winter family and the estate's staff convey the control mechanisms present in hierarchical social structures.

Knowledge and evidence:

- The narrator serves as a lens through which the theme of class is explored
- As an initial paid companion to Mrs Van Hopper, her role highlights the disparities in their social standing:
  - The narrator is acutely conscious of her social status and is mindful of others' perceptions of her while journeying with Mrs Van Hopper
  - Her background as a paid companion places her outside Maxim's aristocratic circles
- The sudden transition from the life of a paid companion to that of the mistress of Manderley marks a stark shift in her social class:
  - Her displacement becomes a central aspect of her identity and shapes her experiences within the aristocratic world of Manderley
- Her decision to marry a man above her own class could be interpreted as challenging the rigid rules of the time concerning social mobility:
  - She defies the expectations imposed by her social standing
  - She also challenges the established norms that typically dictate whom one can or cannot marry
- However, her choice could also be viewed as a decision that she has not made completely independently:
  - Maxim presents her with the choice: "Either you go to America with Mrs Van Hopper, or you come home to Manderley with me":
    - This could imply that a woman of the narrator's social class lacks the privilege of genuine choice and her decision is reduced to choosing which upper-class individual she will depend on

lineage is deeply embedded in the traditions and expectations of the upper class
    - The interactions between the de Winter family and the staff are marked by formality, protocol and an awareness of the social distance between them

- The narrator's lack of knowledge about the established customs, formalities and traditions at Manderley sets her apart from the other members of the upper class:
    - The contrast between her modest background and the grandeur of Manderley further increases her feelings of inadequacy
    - The societal expectations associated with her new role as the lady of Manderley become a constant source of anxiety

- Rebecca is idealised as the epitome of aristocratic grace and sophistication:
    - She sets an unattainable standard for the second Mrs de Winter and it intensifies her class-related insecurities within her marriage

- The narrator struggles with the challenges of fitting into a world defined by class distinctions:
    - However, she does eventually assert her individuality within the constraints of class expectations

What is du Maurier's intention?

- The novel suggests that class divisions not only shape individual experiences but also influence the power dynamics within relationships:
    - It suggests that societal norms and class structures can significantly influence one's sense of self and the opportunities available for personal growth and fulfilment

- It also suggests that the hierarchical structure of society can be a tool for manipulation and control

Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is crucial that you develop the skills to find your own ideas and arrive at your own meanings and interpretations to the text. Try to take a more exploratory and discursive approach to your reading of the text as the examiner will reward you highly for this approach. For instance, you could begin to develop your own interpretations by using sentence starters such as: "Du Maurier may have used the character of Mrs Danvers to highlight ideas about..."

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